school of Mahayana with his half-brother, Asanga, who too lives nearby. Yogacara, as developed in Ayodhya, would become one of the two leading Mahayana schools in India (the other being Madhyamaka, founded by Nagarjuna). Vasubandhu explores ‘the nature of language and the proper and improper ways for a Buddhist to employ scripture and reason’.[19] Xuanzang reveres Vasubandhu and visits the old monastery in Ayodhya where he lived, and the hall where he preached to ‘kings of different countries, eminent men of the world, Sramanas and Brahmins’.

The scene in Prayag (later to be known as Allahabad), however, is very different. Xuanzang finds that ‘the number of heretics [non-Buddhists] is very great’, who are ‘gentle and compliant in their disposition’. Though he doesn’t use the term Kumbh Mela, Xuanzang may have heard about it or witnessed a version of it. He documents the popular belief that by bathing at the confluence of the Ganga and Yamuna, ‘all the pollution of sin is washed away and destroyed; therefore, from various quarters and distant regions people come here together and rest’. Many ascetics who gather here, he writes, practise extreme physical rites and continue ‘this ordeal through several decades of years’. Xuanzang doesn’t think much of these practices. Elsewhere, debating the ‘opinions of the different heretical schools’, he cites the Kapalika ascetics who go naked, hang human bones around their heads and necks and ‘cover themselves with cinders, and think this to be meritorious’. He asks, how can anyone ‘regard these things as proofs of wisdom? Are they not evidences of madness and folly?’[20] Varanasi, he estimates, has about 100 temples with 3000 priests, who mostly honour Shiva, one of whose statues he sees as ‘full of grandeur and majesty’. At Haridwar, multitudes gather ‘from distant quarters to bathe and wash in its waters’. He is very impressed by the Ganga, calling it wide and blue, like the ocean, and its water ‘sweet and pleasant’.

The people in the kingdom of Champa (eastern Bihar) are ‘simple and honest’. Their capital is enclosed by brick walls ‘tens of feet high’. It has many Buddhist monasteries but they are ‘mostly in ruins’. As with so many other observations, Xuanzang doesn’t explain why. South of Champa lie ‘great mountain forests, thick and wild’, with ‘many hundred wild elephants who roam in herds’. Consequently, the elephants in the army of Champa are ‘very numerous. Every now and again they send elephant masters to go